

Primary Source Reading 2: The Boundaries of Reason and Taste

Philosophy Honors: Ethics / Lesson 1.06 — Can Science Ground Ethics? From David Hume, Enquiry Concerning the Principles of Morals, Appendix I (1751)

Before you read: Hume closes his argument by asking why we desire virtue at all — and by tracing the chain of “why” questions all the way down to something that cannot be explained by anything further. As you read, notice the structure of the little dialogue he imagines (health, money, pleasure), and see where the chain of reasons has to stop.

Why Do You Desire Health? A Chain That Must End Somewhere

If you ask a man WHY HE USES EXERCISE, he will answer, BECAUSE HE DESIRES TO KEEP HIS HEALTH. If you then enquire, WHY HE DESIRES HEALTH, he will readily reply, BECAUSE SICKNESS IS PAINFUL. If you push your enquiries farther, and desire a reason WHY HE HATES PAIN, it is impossible he can ever give any. This is an ultimate end, and is never referred to any other object.

...It is impossible there can be a progress IN INFINITUM; and that one thing can always be a reason why another is desired. Something must be desirable on its own account, and because of its immediate accord or agreement with human sentiment and affection.

Now as virtue is an end, and is desirable on its own account, without fee and reward, merely for the immediate satisfaction which it conveys; it is requisite that there should be some sentiment which it touches, some internal taste or feeling, or whatever you may please to call it, which distinguishes moral good and evil, and which embraces the one and rejects the other.

The Distinct Boundaries of Reason and Taste

Thus the distinct boundaries and offices of REASON and of TASTE are easily ascertained. The former conveys the knowledge of truth and falsehood: the latter gives the sentiment of beauty and deformity, vice and virtue. The one discovers objects as they really stand in nature, without addition and diminution: the other has a productive faculty, and gilding or staining all natural objects with the colours, borrowed from internal sentiment, raises in a manner a new creation. Reason being cool and disengaged, is no motive to action, and directs only the impulse received from appetite or inclination, by showing us the means of attaining happiness or avoiding misery: Taste, as it gives pleasure or pain, and thereby constitutes happiness or misery, becomes a motive to action, and is the first spring or impulse to desire and volition.

After you read: Notice what Hume has and has not shown. He has shown that reason alone cannot supply a motive to act — that some feeling has to be added before knowledge of a fact moves us to do anything. But notice also what he has *not* addressed here: what happens when two people's sentiments genuinely conflict, or when someone's sympathy is warm toward their own circle and cold toward strangers. As you write your essay, this is exactly the gap the lesson wants you to press on: if virtue is ultimately a matter of "taste," what settles a dispute between two tastes that disagree?